

01. Power-Sharing

Exercise Questions –

01. What are the different forms of power-sharing in modern democracies? Give an example of each of these.

Power-sharing in modern democracies takes the following forms:

[i] Power shared among different organs of government.

- Power is distributed among the legislature, executive and judiciary.
- This is known as horizontal distribution of power, as all organs operate at same level.
- It ensures no single organ has unlimited power and maintains a system of checks and balances.
- Example- In India, the judiciary can check the actions of the executive and legislature.

[ii] Power shared among different levels of government:

- Power is divided between central and state governments, referred to as the federal government.
- In India, this includes the Union, State and Local governments.
- This is called vertical division of power, as authority is shared between higher and lower levels.
- Example- In India, the constitution clearly defines the powers of the central and state governments.

[iii] Power shared among different social groups:

- Power-sharing ensures representation for diverse communities to prevent alienation from government.
- It helps give minority groups a fair share in power.
- Example- Belgium's 'Community Government'.

[iv] Power shared among political parties, pressure groups and movements:

- Democracy allows citizens to choose from various political contenders.
- Competition among parties prevents the concentration of power.
- In coalition governments, multiple political parties share governance.
- Interest groups, such as business and labour unions, influence decision-making
- Example- India's coalition government at both the central and state levels.

02. State one prudential and moral reason for power-sharing, with an example from India.

- Prudential Reason: Power sharing prevents the tyranny of the majority and ensures political stability by reducing conflicts between social groups.

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- Moral Reason: Those affected by power should have a say in governance, ensuring fairness.
- Example: Reservation policies in government jobs to provide equal opportunities for disadvantaged groups.

03. Three students gave different views on power sharing. Which do you agree with and why?

Thomman: Power-sharing is needed only in societies with religious, linguistic or ethnic divisions.

Mathayi: It is necessary only in large countries with regional divisions.

Ouseph: Every society, regardless of size or division.

I agree with Ouseph. Even in small or homogenous societies, power-sharing fosters inclusivity and prevents future divisions. It strengthens democracy by ensuring broader participation and preventing power concentration in a single authority.

04. A Belgium town, Merchtem, banned speaking French in schools to help non-Dutch speaker integrate. Does this align with Belgium's power-sharing model?

No, this policy contradicts Belgium's power-sharing model. Belgium ensures equal representation for both Dutch and French-speaking communities. The ban enforces linguistic dominance, leading to the tyranny of the majority rather than integration, and could marginalise the French-speaking population.

Notes Questions –

01. What do you mean by ethnic groups?

An ethnic group is a social division based on shared culture and heritage. People belonging to the same ethnic group believe in their common descent because of similarities in physical type, culture, or both. They do not necessarily have to practice the same religion or belong to the same nationality.

02. Discuss the concept of majoritarianism.

Majoritarianism is a political concept which dictates that the majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants, often by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority. For instance, in Sri Lanka, the democratically elected government adopted majoritarian measures to establish Sinhala supremacy, which severely alienated the Tamil minority and eventually led to conflict.

03. What were the conclusions evolved from the conditions of Belgium and Sri Lanka conflict?

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- Belgium: Concluded that the unity of a country is only possible by respecting the feelings and interests of different communities. By accommodating diversity and sharing power equally, they maintained peace.
- Sri Lanka: Demonstrated the opposite; if a majority community tries to force its dominance over others and refuses to share power, it severely undermines the unity of the country and can lead to disastrous outcomes.

04. What do you mean by civil war? What are the conditions that rebuke (cause) civil war?

A civil war is a violent conflict between opposing groups within a country that becomes so intense that it appears like an actual war. The conditions that trigger a civil war usually stem from severe alienation and discrimination. When a government adopts majoritarian policies, denies a minority group equal political and educational rights, and completely refuses to share power—as seen with the Tamils in Sri Lanka—the resulting social frustration often escalates into a full-scale civil war.

05. "A democratic country must have prominent feature of power-sharing". Support or rebuke the statement.

I strongly support this statement. Morally, power-sharing is fundamentally the "spirit of democracy" because a legitimate democratic government is one where citizens acquire a stake in the system through active participation. Prudentially, it is essential because it drastically reduces the possibility of violent conflict and political instability between different social groups, ensuring the long-term survival and unity of the nation.

06. Discuss the cons of power-sharing in a democratic nation.

While beneficial, power-sharing does have some practical drawbacks:

- Delayed Decision-Making: Because power is distributed among various groups or coalition partners, arriving at a consensus takes much more time compared to a single-ruler system.
- Administrative Inefficiency: Constant negotiation and compromise can sometimes water down strong, necessary policies to keep all sharing partners satisfied.
- Political Instability: In cases of coalition governments, if the power-sharing partners disagree or withdraw their support, the government can easily collapse.

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07. What can be the suitable form of power-sharing in a democratic country?

In modern democracies, power-sharing arrangements generally take these four forms:

1. Horizontal Distribution: Power is shared among different organs of the government (legislature, executive, and judiciary).
2. Vertical Distribution: Power is shared among governments at different levels (central, state, and local).
3. Among Social Groups: Power is shared among different religious or linguistic communities.
4. Among Political Parties: Power is shared through political competition, pressure groups, and coalition governments.

08. How power can be shared among different levels of government?

Power shared among different levels of government is known as vertical power-sharing or federalism. In this system, power is divided between a general central government that handles national affairs and regional or state governments that manage local administration. The constitution clearly lays down the distinct powers of each level so the central authority cannot dictate terms to the states. In countries like India, this extends even further down to a third tier comprising local municipalities and panchayats.

09. Differentiate between power-sharing at social groups and power-sharing in political parties.

Power-Sharing among Social Groups:

- Nature of Sharing: Power is formally distributed among different religious, linguistic, or socially weaker sections of society.
- Main Objective: The primary goal is to give minority and marginalized communities a fair share in administration so they do not feel alienated from the government.
- Real-World Examples: The "Community Government" in Belgium (which handles cultural and educational issues for specific language groups) and the system of "Reserved Constituencies" in India for socially weaker sections.

Power-Sharing among Political Parties:

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- Nature of Sharing: Power is shared among different political organizations that actively compete against each other in democratic elections.
- Main Objective: The goal is to ensure that power does not remain concentrated in one hand or one ideology, providing citizens with a clear choice of leadership.
- Real-World Examples: A "Coalition Government," which is formed when two or more political parties join hands to form a government because no single party secured a clear majority on its own.

Extra Questions –

01. How did the idea of power-sharing emerge?

The idea of power-sharing emerged in direct opposition to the old notion of undivided political power. For a long time, it was believed that all power of a government must reside in one person or a single group at one place, because otherwise, it would be too difficult to make quick decisions and enforce them. However, the rise of democracy changed this. The basic principle of democracy is that people are the source of all political power, making it essential to distribute power among the citizens.

02. 'Sharing power makes a country more powerful and united.' Justify.

Sharing power makes a country more powerful and united because it actively prevents the marginalisation of minority groups. When a government respects the feelings, cultures, and interests of different communities, it builds mutual trust and a sense of belonging.

As seen in the case of Belgium, accommodating diversity and giving different groups a share in power prevented the country from dividing along linguistic lines. Conversely, when a majority community tries to force its dominance and refuse to share its power (as in Sri Lanka), it breeds resentment, sparks violent conflicts, and ultimately weakens the unity and strength of the entire nation.

03. Describe the elements of the Belgium model for accommodating diversities.

- Equal representation: The central government has an equal number of Dutch and French-speaking ministers. No single community can make decisions unilaterally.
- State autonomy: State governments are given significant powers and are not subordinate to the central government.
- Separate government for Brussels: The capital city has its own government where both French and Dutch-speaking communities have equal representation.

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- Community government: A third tier of government elected by specific language communities to exclusively handle cultural, educational, and language issues.

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